What about what's being queried? How do you determine which queries are currently running?

PostgreSQL makes current activity available from a *system catalog* view called pg_stat_activity. This might be the first system catalog view you've worked with.

PostgreSQL keeps metadata internally and bookkeeping information in the pg_catalog[5] System Catalogs. System Catalog tables start with pg_* and shouldn't be modified. They're very useful to inspect more about what's happening inside PostgreSQL.

To view current database activity, launch psql and run this SQL query:

sql/pg_stat_activity.sql

```
SELECT * FROM pg_stat_activity;
```

Try toggling \x (another meta-command) to make the output more readable. Even if no application queries are running, you might see things like "auto-vacuum launcher" or "logical replication launcher", which are background processes running within PostgreSQL.

To inspect details about the psql session you've opened, you can query pg_stat_activity by the pid, using the pid for your own current backend process from SELECT * FROM pg_backend_pid();:

```
SELECT * FROM pg_stat_activity WHERE pid = (SELECT * FROM pg_backend_pid());
```

It is safe to run this command in your production database to view the activity from system catalogs. In production on a live system you may find an overwhelming amount of information when querying the pg_stat_activity view. If you see INSUFFICIENT PRIVILEGES when querying it, you'll need to connect to your database using an administrator role.

Take a look at the pid Process ID field.[6] If you have a query that's running too long and you want to stop it, you'll need the pid.

From psql with the pid, the PostgreSQL System Administration functions describe how a *backend* has a query. To stop a query you'll cancel the backend using System Administration Functions.[7]

```
SELECT PG_CANCEL_BACKEND(pid);
```

With the cancel form, a SIGINT signal is sent which attempts a graceful shut-down.

5. https://www.postgresql.org/docs/current/catalogs-overview.html
6. https://www.postgresql.org/docs/current/monitoring-stats.html#MONITORING-PG-STAT-ACTIVITY-VIEW
7. https://www.postgresql.org/docs/current/functions-admin.html